

Mert Yazan

PhD Candidate · Human-AI Interaction

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RESEARCH PROFILE

PhD candidate at Leiden University and Hogeschool van Amsterdam, working on human-centered AI safety. I study how the warmth, empathy, and personalization of LLMs change what people believe and how much they rely on them, including overreliance on wrong answers and AI persuasion. I combine online experiments and large surveys with model-side evaluations of LLMs. Since 2026, I have also worked on digital minds.

EXPERIENCE

PhD Researcher, Leiden University & Hogeschool van Amsterdam

Feb 2023 – Jan 2027

Supervisors: Suzan Verberne, Frederik Situmeang

- Ran three online experiments (N = 199, 380, 629) on how LLM warmth, personalization, and emotion acknowledgment shape trust, reliance, and persuasion. A warm style raised agreement with an LLM assistant's wrong answers.
- Co-led a seven-country survey (N = 4,641) on LLM use for emotional support. The first paper appears at EMNLP 2026.
- Built a sycophancy-evaluation pipeline for open-weight LLMs, with linear probes and activation steering.
- Testing whether stated user demographics change LLM replies to mental-wellbeing prompts.

Digital Minds Research, self-directed alongside the PhD

2026 – present

- Wrote *The Assistant's Ideal Self* at the Apart Research Digital Minds Research Sprint (Aug 2026), co-organized with NYU CMEP and Eleos AI.
- Designing an experiment on public and expert judgments of AI sentience.

Data Scientist, Fibabanka, Istanbul

Aug 2019 – Dec 2021

- Built and deployed an interpretable machine-learning model to replace the bank's rule-based credit-scoring system.
- Built the data pipeline in Oracle SQL. Monitored the model in Power BI and automated retraining with Apache Airflow.

EDUCATION

PhD, Human-AI Interaction

Feb 2023 – Jan 2027 (expected)

Leiden University & Hogeschool van Amsterdam

MSc, Computer Vision

2021 – 2022

Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona

BSc, Computer Engineering

2013 – 2019

Galatasaray University

SKILLS

Programming	Python, R, SQL (PostgreSQL, Oracle), JavaScript, TypeScript
LLMs	PyTorch, Hugging Face Transformers, LoRA fine-tuning, llama.cpp, RAG, linear probes, activation steering
Human studies	Experimental design, survey methodology, mixed-effects models, SEM (lavaan), mediation analysis, power analysis, Qualtrics, Prolific
Engineering	Gradio, FastAPI, Chrome extensions, SLURM, Apache Airflow, Power BI
Languages	Turkish (native), English (C2)

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed

1. N. Amat-Lefort*, **M. Yazan***, A. Cercas Curry, F. M. Plaza-del-Arco. From Chatbots to Confidants: A Cross-Cultural Study of LLM Adoption for Emotional Support. *EMNLP 2026, Main Conference*. *Equal contribution. [arXiv](#)
2. **M. Yazan**, S. Verberne, F. Situmeang. Personalized to Persuade: The Effects of Contextualization and Warmth on Trust and Reliance in Conversational AI. *HAI '26, Poster Papers*. [arXiv](#)
3. R. Xiao, **M. Yazan**, F. Situmeang. Rethinking Conversation Styles of Chatbots from the Customer Perspective. *International Journal of Human-Computer Interaction*, 41(2), 2025. [DOI](#)
4. **M. Yazan**, S. Verberne, F. Situmeang. Improving RAG for Personalization with Author Features and Contrastive Examples. *ECIR 2025*. [DOI](#)
5. **M. Yazan**. User-Adaptive Personalized Chatbots for Conversational Information-Seeking Tasks. *CHIIR '25*. [DOI](#)
6. **M. Yazan**, S. Verberne, F. Situmeang. The Impact of Quantization on Retrieval-Augmented Generation: An Analysis of Small LLMs. *IR-RAG Workshop @ SIGIR 2024*. [arXiv](#)

Under review and preprints

1. **M. Yazan**, F. Situmeang, S. Verberne. The Decision to Verify: How Warmth and User Characteristics Shape Reliance on Conversational Agents for Information Search. Under review, *Computers in Human Behavior Reports*. [arXiv](#)
2. **M. Yazan**, S. Verberne, F. Situmeang. I See That You Are Frustrated: An Analysis of Emotion Acknowledgment's Influence on Privacy Risk and Satisfaction. Under review, *Behaviour & Information Technology*. [SSRN](#)
3. N. Amat-Lefort, **M. Yazan**, A. Cercas Curry, F. M. Plaza-del-Arco. Who Trusts AI with Their Emotions? Trust Formation and Sociodemographic Variation in LLM Use for Emotional Support. Under review, *International Journal of Human-Computer Interaction*. [arXiv](#)
4. **M. Yazan**. The Assistant's Ideal Self. Digital Minds Research Sprint, Apart Research. Preprint. [arXiv](#)

TEACHING, TALKS & SERVICE

- Thesis supervision (2025–2026): X. Wang (BSc, Leiden University), D. Kadah Salim (BSc, Leiden University), M. Ramadan (MSc, HvA), A. F. Ammar (MSc, HvA).
- Database Management course (2023–2026): designed a SQL assignment to study how students use AI while learning.
- Talk, Computational Linguistics Seminar, ILLC, University of Amsterdam (Nov 2025).
- Co-organizer, Workshop on Conversational Search for Complex Information Needs (CoSCIN), ECIR 2026.
- Participant, Introduction to Digital Minds course, Cambridge Digital Minds (2026, ongoing).